

Playful Learning Expansion Pack

An Appendix for Integrating Playful Learning into Park in a Truck Projects

What Is Playful Learning?

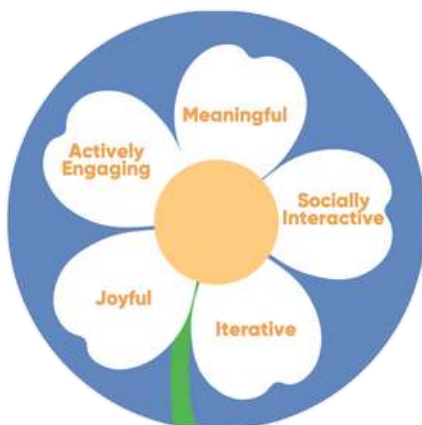
Playful Learning brings together the science of how children learn best with the design of everyday spaces. It combines the joy of play with meaningful, interactive opportunities to support child development—turning sidewalks, parks, and community spaces into places where learning naturally unfolds. Grounded in developmental science, Playful Learning experiences are active, engaging, socially interactive, and joyful.

This approach supports **whole-child development**, helping children build not only academic skills, but also social, emotional, physical, and creative abilities. Children strengthen their language through storytelling, develop critical thinking through hands-on problem solving, grow confidence by exploring new ideas, and build social skills through collaboration and communication with peers and caregivers.

Since **children spend nearly 80% of their waking hours outside of formal classroom settings**, public spaces—like parks, sidewalks, and plazas—hold tremendous potential as platforms for learning. When we embed Playful Learning into these environments, we meet children and families where they are, turning everyday moments into opportunities to grow, connect, and thrive.

The Playful Learning Landscapes Design Formula

Playful Learning Landscapes (PLL) uses a three-part design formula that ensures installations are community-driven, evidence-based, and designed to build essential skills:



HOW Children Learn

+



WHAT Children Learn

+

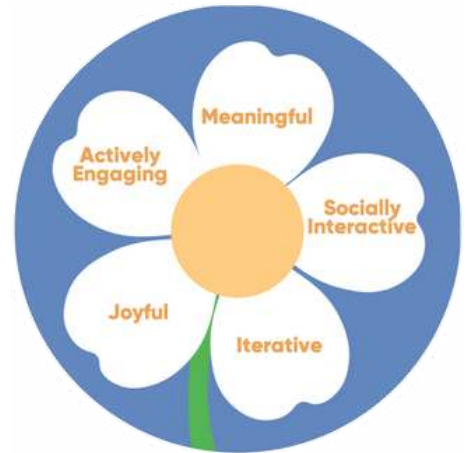


Community Engagement

5 Principles of Learning (The *HOW*)

Playful Learning spaces are grounded in decades of research from developmental psychology and education. Designs reflect five key principles that describe how children learn best:

- **Actively Engaging:** Children learn most effectively when they are physically and mentally engaged. Activities that involve movement, manipulation, or experimentation promote deeper understanding.
- **Meaningful:** Learning sticks when it connects to a child's life experiences, interests, and cultural background. Content that resonates personally helps children build on what they already know.
- **Socially Interactive:** Peer and caregiver interactions are critical to learning. Conversation, shared tasks, and collaborative exploration help children reflect, clarify, and expand their thinking.
- **Iterative:** Children benefit from opportunities to try things out, make mistakes, and try again. Environments that allow for repeated use and flexible problem-solving promote persistence and adaptive thinking.
- **Joyful:** Joy is not just nice—it's necessary! When children are curious, delighted, and emotionally invested, they are more likely to stay engaged and motivated to learn.



The 6Cs Framework (The *WHAT*)

Playful Learning Landscapes are designed to promote six interconnected skills that children need to thrive in school, work, and life. Known as the 6Cs, these competencies build on one another and are especially important in the early years:



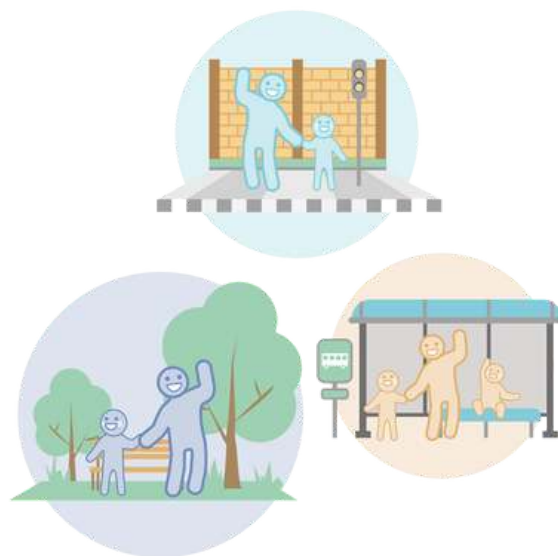
- **Collaboration:** The ability to work and play well with others. Children practice sharing, turn-taking, negotiating, and resolving conflict—essential skills for teamwork and community life.
- **Communication:** The ability to express ideas clearly and understand others. Through storytelling, asking questions, listening, and explaining, children build oral language, vocabulary, and social-emotional understanding.
- **Content:** The acquisition of knowledge in academic and everyday domains, including math, science, reading, and social studies. Playful learning activities offer natural opportunities to explore new information and apply it meaningfully.

- **Critical Thinking:** The ability to analyze, compare, predict, and solve problems. Whether sorting objects, following multi-step prompts, or completing a puzzle, children learn to make decisions and test ideas.
- **Creative Innovation:** The ability to think outside the box. Children develop flexible thinking, imagination, and invention—skills that help them adapt to change and come up with new solutions.
- **Confidence:** The belief in one’s ability to try, fail, and try again. Confidence grows when children take initiative, make decisions, and feel a sense of accomplishment. This builds resilience and curiosity.

The 6Cs are not taught in isolation—they emerge through the kinds of rich, hands-on, social experiences that Playful Learning encourages.

Community Engagement

Community members are involved in every step of the design process—from concept to implementation. By inviting local families, youth, and educators to share their ideas and values, Playful Learning installations become more relevant, reflective, and inclusive. Co-design also fosters local pride and long-term stewardship.



Playful Learning Landscapes x Park in a Truck

Playful Learning Landscapes (PLL) is a natural partner for Park in a Truck (PiaT). Both initiatives center equity, accessibility, and community voice. PiaT turns vacant lots into parks that are easy to build, easy to maintain, and rooted in local leadership. PLL adds another layer—infusing those parks with educational value and joyful experiences.

Together, they:

- Embrace **community-driven design**
- Reinforce **public spaces as platforms for equity**
- Align with PiaT’s commitment to **accessible, flexible, and community-owned environments**
- Expand opportunities for **learning in everyday moments**

Playful Learning Designs for PiaT Projects

Element	Description	Key Skills (6Cs)
Shape Games	Painted shapes encourage children to jump between colors and forms, fostering movement and logic.	Content, Critical Thinking, Confidence
Icon Storytelling	Children choose etched icons on gabion baskets to build stories, promoting narrative play.	Collaboration, Communication, Creative Innovation
Color-Theory Trellis	Overlapping transparent panels show how colors blend, encouraging visual experimentation.	Content, Critical Thinking, Communication
Sorting Tables	Tables with gridded surfaces prompt sorting by shape, size, or texture.	Content, Critical Thinking, Communication
I-Spy Key Mural	A mural encourages children to search for objects around the park, boosting observation skills.	Content, Collaboration, Critical Thinking
Puzzle Wall	Children complete a puzzle of a meaningful community image, promoting problem-solving.	Collaboration, Critical Thinking, Confidence
Giant Ruler	A painted ruler invites children to measure themselves or objects, linking math to real-world context.	Content, Confidence, Communication
Color Theory Sculpture	Moveable colored petals allow children to mix colors through play.	Creative Innovation, Content, Collaboration
Jumping Feet	A twist on hopscotch that challenges children to switch jumping styles.	Confidence, Critical Thinking, Collaboration
Story Wheel	A spinning wheel provides prompts for children to invent stories, solo or with peers.	Communication, Creative Innovation, Collaboration

PLL Integration into PiaT Park Types

These elements can be adapted to fit any of PiaT's four modular park themes:

Park Type	Recommended Playful Learning Features
Edible	Sorting Tables, Story Wheel, Giant Ruler, Icon Storytelling
Sanctuary	Puzzle Wall, Color-Theory Trellis, Icon Storytelling, Color Flower Sculpture
Nature	I-Spy Mural, Jumping Feet, Sorting Tables, Shape Games
Event	Story Wheel, Shape Games, Jumping Feet, Icon Storytelling

These playful elements are intentionally designed to be low-cost, low-maintenance, and customizable—aligning seamlessly with PiaT's goals and methods. Whether activating a garden corner, designing a mural wall, or creating a flexible seating area, Playful Learning can enhance engagement and expand opportunity.

Learn More and Get in Touch

To explore additional resources, case studies, and downloadable tools, visit the **Playful Learning Landscapes website**: www.playfullearninglandscapes.com

For questions or support, contact the PLL team at:
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